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Industry reformulates food after red dye No. 3 ban

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The Food and Drug Administration (FDA) eliminated the use of red dye No. 3 in foods and beverages, marking a milestone in food regulation. This synthetic dye, present in more than 3,000 products, generated controversy for decades due to studies linking it to cancer in animals. Although the change has just begun, the implications are already being felt in the industry and by consumers.

A history of risk and debate The petroleum-derived red No. 3 was approved more than a century ago, but its risks have been known since the 1990s. Studies showed that high doses caused tumors in rats, which led to a ban in cosmetics, although it continued in foods and medicines. According to an NBC News report, organizations such as the Center for Science in the Public Interest lobbied for years for a ban, stressing that no amount is safe.

Other artificial dyes are also of concern. Researchers warned about red No. 40 and blue No. 2, noting that they affect neurological development and increase the risk of tumors in animals. In addition, yellow No. 5 was shown to be capable of altering behavior in sensitive children and causing sleep problems.

Natural alternatives on the horizon Although the complete ban will become effective in 2027, some companies have already initiated the switch. Ferrara, maker of popular candies, said that less than 10% of its products still contain the dye. Just Born, maker of Peeps candy, said it eliminated red No. 3 after the last Easter season. These companies are moving toward cleaner recipes, which is good for millions of consumers.

Experts and legislators are betting on natural substitutes. Options such as beet and pomegranate juices stand out as viable alternatives. Although some manufacturers argued that these options raise costs, an analysis presented in the California legislation showed that, in many cases, natural ingredients are cheaper.

"These changes should not affect prices; companies have already implemented them in Europe," said Jesse Gabriel, an advocate for natural ingredients,

Jesse Gabriel, the state's sponsor of the law, told NBC News. What's next for the food industry? The red No. 3 veto poses a challenge for the industry. Many brands will need to reformulate products, and while alternatives are available, the pace of adoption varies. According to Melanie Benesh of the Environmental Working Group, the move represents a "big win" for consumers, but she warned that some companies may choose to replace it with other equally controversial dyes, such as red No. 40.

In addition, a lack of transparency continues to complicate the situation. Currently, labels do not specify the amount of colorants in each product. Experts such as Thomas Galligan, quoted in CNN, pointed out that this information could help consumers make more informed decisions.

Goodbye to red No. 3 now Eliminating red No. 3 is an important step in reducing risks associated with the consumption of artificial additives. According to Dr. Michael Hansen of Consumer Reports, this decision reinforces the importance of questioning what we consume and how it affects our health.

"While the dye is not the only culprit, reducing its exposure benefits both children and adults."

However, the discussion does not end here. Other countries, such as those in the European Union, outlawed several dyes decades ago, while in the United States, regulations are moving slowly. This change opens the door for more additives to be evaluated with updated standards, something experts consider essential.

Red No. 3 exits the scene, but its legacy reminds us that social pressure, backed by research, can transform industries. With safer alternatives available, the transition to foods free of harmful chemicals seems inevitable. Will this be the start of a broader change on our tables?

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